Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Hebrews

Hebrews 1:1

On many past occasions means the time before the Messiah's arrival. For the author of Hebrews, this mainly meant the Old Testament era. During that time, God spoke often and in various ways through:

- dreams,
- visions,
- powerful acts,
- stories,
- commands,
- encouragements,
- angelic appearances, and
- appearances of God himself.

The prophets were all those people through whom God shared his message (see 2 Peter 1:19–21).

Hebrews 1:1–2

On many past occasions ... but in these last days: These verses compare two time periods when God spoke. Comparing the two periods side by side shows the differences between them.

Hebrews 1:1–4

Ancient sermons often began with an introduction. This introduction served two purposes:

1. to capture the listener's attention, and
2. to present the main topics.

In Hebrews, the first four verses are a single, elegant Greek sentence. The introduction presents the main idea: God has spoken. Most English translations break these verses into smaller sentences to make them easier to read.

Hebrews 1:2

- These last days refers to the historical period that began with Christ's arrival (see Isaiah 2:2; Acts 2:17). In the Old Testament era, revelations came in many forms over time. However, God's ultimate revelation came through his Son, Jesus (see Hebrews 2:3–4).
- heir of all things: Christ is God's royal heir. This is likely a reference to Psalm 2:8.

Hebrews 1:3

- The Greek word translated radiance is found only here in the New Testament. It means intense brightness. God's glory shows his presence (Exodus 16:7; 33:18; Isaiah 40:5). The Son's glory reflects God's glory, showing God's presence (Luke 9:32; John 1:14; 2:11; 17:5; Romans 8:17).
- The Greek word translated exact representation is also unique in the New Testament. It refers to a mark like one on a coin. The Son clearly shows God's character (John 1:18; Philippians 2:6; Colossians 1:15).
- His powerful word: This phrase means God's word is a strong and active force that created and controls the world (Hebrews 11:3; Psalm 33:6–11). The Son is also called "the Word of God" (Revelation 19:13; see also John 1:1–18).
- He cleansed us from our sins (see Hebrews 9:11–10:18).
- He sat down: This refers to Psalm 110:1 (see also Hebrews 1:13; 8:1; 10:12; 12:2). The Psalm predicted Christ's honor after his suffering (see Matthew 22:44; Acts 2:33; 1 Corinthians 15:25). The right hand of God shows high honor and position (see 1 Kings 2:19; Psalms 16:11; 45:4, 9; 80:17).

Hebrews 1:4

- The Son's high position shows that the Son is much greater than the angels in status or rank. First-century Jews admired angels and respected them greatly. By comparing him to the angels, the author of Hebrews emphasizes the Son's superiority over them.
- as the name He has inherited is excellent beyond theirs: Compare 2 Samuel 7:8–14. Some commentators believe that the title "Son" is the name implied here. Others think the name is Yahweh, the covenant name of God in the Old Testament (Exodus 3:14–15; compare Philippians 2:9–11).

Hebrews 1:5

- did God ever say: This verse quotes Psalm 2:7 and 2 Samuel 7:14. By raising Jesus to his right hand, the Father declared his special relationship with the Son (see Acts 1:9–11; 2:32–36; 7:55–56).
- Today I have become your Father (literally Today I have begotten You): Jesus did not become the Son at the exaltation (when God raised Jesus to heaven and gave him the highest honor). He had been involved in creation (Hebrews 1:2). The exaltation confirmed his identity to everyone.

Hebrews 1:5–14

In these ten verses, the writer uses many Old Testament passages to prove that Jesus is greater than the angels. In ancient Jewish and Christian teaching, people often placed several Old Testament passages

together in a row. This practice was called "chain quotations" or "pearl stringing." The goal was to convince the listeners or readers of a truth by giving a strong group of scriptural proofs at once.

Hebrews 1:6

- The supreme (or firstborn) Son was understood to have certain rights. The firstborn son shared the father's authority. A firstborn also inherited most of the father's property and was especially favored. In the New Testament, "firstborn" often refers to Christ's supreme status in both the church and the world. His resurrection is often cited as proof of this status (Acts 13:33; Romans 1:4; 8:29; Colossians 1:15, 18; Revelation 1:5; compare Hebrews 12:23, where believers are called firstborn children).
- "Let all God's angels worship him.": This quotation from Deuteronomy 32:43 shows that angels are of lower status because they worship the Son (see also Psalm 97:7).

Hebrews 1:7

- This verse quotes Psalm 104:4 to show that angels are messengers or servants. They have a lower rank than the Son, whom they serve.
- In the Old Testament, angels are sometimes associated with winds and fire (see Exodus 3:2; Judges 6:21; 13:16, 20; 2 Samuel 22:11; Psalms 18:10; 35:5). This shows the angels' connection with God's rule over nature.

Hebrews 1:8–9

- These verses, quoting Psalm 45:6–7, declare the Son as the divine, just, eternal, anointed King of the universe.
- But about the Son He says: Jesus is called God. In Hebrews 1:9, "your God" refers to God the Father.
- has anointed you ... with the oil of joy: Olive oil was used to anoint Israel's kings when they began their rule (1 Samuel 10:1; 1 Kings 19:15–16). To anoint someone was to pour oil on that person's head as a public sign that God had chosen them for a special role. God has anointed his Son, Jesus Christ, as King.

Hebrews 1:10–12

These verses, quoting Psalm 102:25–27, celebrate the Son as both the creator and the one who ends creation. All created things will wear out like old clothing, and the Son will discard them (compare Hebrews 2:5; 2 Peter 3:13; Revelation 21:1). In contrast, the Son of God will live forever.

Hebrews 1:13

- The author ends this series of Old Testament quotes by citing Psalm 110:1. This verse celebrates Christ's exaltation (see also study notes on Luke 20:42–43; 22:69; 1 Corinthians 15:25; Ephesians 1:19–22).
- The image of the Son's enemies as a footstool under his feet shows their complete defeat (see Hebrews 2:8). In ancient times, a victorious king would place his foot on an enemy's neck or back as a sign of control.

Hebrews 1:14

Are not the angels ministering spirits: The author repeats his conclusion. God sends angels to help his people, who will receive salvation at the end of time (see Hebrews 9:28).

Hebrews 2:1

- What we have heard is the message of salvation delivered through Christ (Hebrews 2:3).
- So that we do not drift away is like a ship going off course. Here, it means losing spiritual focus by not paying close attention to the Good News.

Hebrews 2:1–4

The author argues from a smaller example to a larger one. In the Old Testament era, people who rejected God's word delivered by angels were punished. If that was true, then the punishment will be even greater for those who now reject the message of salvation. This message has been given by the Son himself and confirmed by the Holy Spirit.

Hebrews 2:2

- According to Jewish tradition, God gave the law on Mount Sinai through angelss (see Acts 7:38; Galatians 3:19).
- Breaking the law led to punishment (see Exodus 22:19; Leviticus 20:10; Numbers 35:16–21). The punishment could not be escaped (see Proverbs 1:24–31; Jeremiah 11:11).

Hebrews 2:3

- Why do we think we can avoid consequences? The author emphasizes the serious danger of rejecting Christ and his salvation. There is no escape from punishment for those who turn away, and the punishment will be very severe (see Hebrews 6:4–12; 10:26–31; 12:29; Romans 2:5; 1 Thessalonians 2:16).
- Salvation means God's actions to help his people. For example, God saved his people when he brought them out of Egypt in the exodus (Deuteronomy

26:5–9). In the New Testament, salvation generally refers to Christ's sacrificial death on the cross. This action saved people from the consequences of sin and gave them new life (Hebrews 5:9–10). Jesus first announced this salvation himself (for example, Matthew 4:17; 9:35; Mark 1:15; Luke 13:1–5). He then confirmed the message through those who heard him speak (for example, Mark 6:12; Acts 2:38; 3:19–20).

Hebrews 2:4

affirmed by God: God himself proved the truth of Christ's message and his followers. He provided signs, wonders, various miracles, and gifts of the Holy Spirit (see Acts 2:22; Romans 15:19; 2 Corinthians 12:12).

Hebrews 2:5

it is not to angels: Compare Hebrews 1:13.

Hebrews 2:5–9

The author of Hebrews uses Psalm 8:4–6 to shift from discussing Christ's divine nature in Hebrews 1:5–14 to his human nature in 2:10–18. Psalm 8 is often paired with Psalm 110:1 (see Hebrews 1:13) to describe how all creation submits to Christ (see 1 Corinthians 15:25–27; Ephesians 1:20–23). Christ is the perfect human. In his exaltation, he achieves true dominion over creation, something humanity could not do.

Hebrews 2:6

- What is man: These lines of the psalm highlight God's special care for humans.
- the son of Man: The term son of man refers to human life and is similar to man in the previous line. In the Gospels, Jesus often used this phrase to describe himself.

Hebrews 2:6–8

These verses quote Psalm 8:4–6. Psalm 8 talks about the position God has given to humanity. The author of Hebrews uses the verse to predict Christ, who fulfills and represents humanity.

Hebrews 2:7

- him: This refers to all of humanity and specifically to Christ (see study note on 2:6–8).
- Christ became a little lower than the angels (or a little while lower). In other words, Christ became like other humans (see also Philippians 2:5–8).
- crowned him with glory and honor: Because of his suffering, he was given the highest honor and praise (see Hebrews 2:9; Philippians 2:9–11).

Hebrews 2:8

- placed everything under his feet: See study note on 2:6–8.
- He left nothing outside of his control: All things are ultimately under the authority of Christ and the church. However, we have not yet seen this fully happen. Only at the end of the age (the final period of time when Jesus returns) will it be completed.

Hebrews 2:9

But we see Jesus: How can the church continue when evil and death exist? We look to Jesus in his human life, where he was "a little lower than the angels." We also look to him in his exaltation, where he is now "crowned with glory and honor." His suffering as a human led to his exaltation (see Philippians 2:5–11; compare Isaiah 52:13–53:12). See also Hebrews 12:1–13.

Hebrews 2:10

- sons: The author uses the title Son for Jesus and refers to God's people as sons. The translation children clarifies that it includes all of God's people, both male and female.
- The term author had many meanings in the ancient world. It could also mean founder, hero, champion, prince, captain, leader, or scout. Jesus is called the author because he began the work of salvation and guides people to glory.

Hebrews 2:10–18

This passage suggests at least four reasons why the Son of God became human.

1. It was appropriate: It aligns with God's character to achieve salvation this way (Hebrews 2:10).
2. Jesus needed to become human to die (2:14).
3. According to Old Testament law, high priests had to be chosen from among God's people (2:17).
4. Jesus became a compassionate priest by experiencing human suffering and challenges (2:18).

Hebrews 2:11

- of the same family (literally are all out of one): In this context, "Father" likely refers to God. However, the author might have been thinking of Abraham as a shared ancestor (see Hebrews 2:16) or of human nature as a shared experience (out of one nature).
- brothers: The Greek word adelphoi is a general term for family members, both male and female.

Hebrews 2:12

This verse quotes Psalm 22:22 and discusses the term brothers and sisters in Hebrews 2:11. Psalm 22 includes important prophecies about Christ's suffering (Psalm 22:1, 7–8, 16–18; see Matthew 27:35, 43; John 19:23–24, 31–36). Psalm 22:22 highlights how the righteous sufferer (Jesus) joins God's people in praising God for His help.

Hebrews 2:13

- This verse quotes Isaiah 8:17–18, which is part of a larger context about the Messiah (compare Isaiah 8:14 with Romans 9:33; 1 Peter 2:8).
- "I will put my trust in Him.": This shows that Jesus trusts God the Father.
- "I, and the children God has given Me.": This shows the close relationship between Jesus and God's children.

Hebrews 2:14–15

- The death of the Son of God as a sacrifice for sin weakened the devil's power. It made the devil's power over death ineffective (1 Corinthians 15:56).
- Philo, a first-century Jewish philosopher, wrote that "nothing enslaves the mind like fearing death" (Philo, That Every Good Person Is Free 3.22). Through his sacrificial death, Christ freed those who were slaves to the fear of dying.

Hebrews 2:16

descendants of Abraham: Jesus died on the cross for those who inherit God's promises to Abraham, not for the angels.

Hebrews 2:17–18

- These verses introduce Jesus as our kind and loyal high priest, a role fully explained in the main part of Hebrews (Hebrews 4:14–10:25).
- He needed to share our human experience (see 5:1).

Hebrews 3:1

- holy brothers: In ancient times, speakers and writers often called religious groups "brothers" (Greek adelphoi), including both men and women. Many modern translations use "brothers and sisters."
- set your focus on Jesus: Focusing on Jesus helps you stay strong in your faith (Hebrews 2:9; 12:1–2).
- the apostle: This term may emphasize the Son's role in sharing God's name and message (2:12; Matt 10:40; Mark 9:37; Luke 10:16).

Hebrews 3:1–6

The author compares Jesus to Moses, presenting Jesus as the ultimate example of faithfulness. Moses was a highly honored leader in Judaism. His respected status is used to show that Jesus is even greater than Moses.

Hebrews 3:2

Jesus was loyal to God and the mission given to him by the Father (Hebrews 5:7–10; 12:1–3; Philippians 2:5–11), just like Moses was (Numbers 12:7). Many Jews in the first century saw Moses as the greatest person in history, even more important than angels.

Hebrews 3:3–6

Jesus deserves more glory for two reasons:

1. A person who builds a house deserves more praise than the house itself. The Messiah is the one who builds God's house (see 2 Samuel 7:13). This implies that Moses is part of the house (God's people) that God has built.
2. While Moses was a servant in God's house, Christ, as the Son, is the heir in charge of God's entire house. Sons have a higher status than household servants.

Hebrews 3:6

We belong to God's house if we act courageously. The author could not fully assure those who were drifting away from Christ and the church. Those who continue in faith can be sure they are part of God's house (see Hebrews 3:14; Romans 8:9, 17; 11:22; 2 Corinthians 13:5; Colossians 1:22–23).

Hebrews 3:7–19

This passage serves as a warning, showing the negative example of those who wandered in the wilderness for forty years and died there. The wilderness wanderings symbolize disobedience to God and its consequences (see Numbers 32:7–11; Deuteronomy 1:19–35; Psalm 106:24–26).

Hebrews 3:8

The Israelites rebelled and tested God in places like Massah and Meribah, where water was scarce (Exodus 17:1–7; Numbers 20:2–13). They especially disobeyed at Kadesh by refusing to enter the promised land (Hebrews 3:10; see Numbers 14:1–25; Deuteronomy 1:19–46; Psalm 106).

Hebrews 3:9–10

Even after witnessing the miracles God performed for them, the people of Israel tested God's patience by not trusting him in the wilderness (Numbers 14:11, 22). Their rebellion stemmed from their hearts consistently turning away from God. They did not want to obey God. As a result, God became angry with them.

Hebrews 3:11

- Rebellion has consequences.
- God's anger is not just an emotional reaction. It is his fair and just response to sin (John 3:36; Romans 1:18; 1 Thessalonians 2:16).
- God's promise (see Hebrews 6:13–20; 7:20–22, 28) was that they would never enter Canaan, the land of rest from their travels (Deuteronomy 1:19–46; 3:20; 12:10; Joshua 1:13).

Hebrews 3:12

heart of unbelief that turns away from the living God: An evil heart stubbornly resists the Lord because of unbelief, leading a person to turn away from the living God.

Hebrews 3:12–19

The author of Hebrews points to important words from Psalm 95. These include heart, today, hear, enter, rest, and unbelief. In the ancient world, Bible teachers would cite a passage from the Old Testament and then explain it. They often highlighted key words from the passage, much like preachers do today. This style of explanation was called midrash (a type of Jewish Bible interpretation).

Hebrews 3:13

The author uses the word "today" from Psalms 95:7 to urge people to remind each other daily about the misleading and toughening effects of sin.

Hebrews 3:14

If we stay faithful, we can be sure we belong to God's family (see Hebrews 3:6; Romans 8:9, 17; 11:22; 2 Corinthians 13:5; Colossians 1:22–23).

Hebrews 3:15

This verse quotes Psalm 95:7–8, urging readers to listen and respond positively to God's voice. It summarizes the author's message in Hebrews 3:12–14.

Hebrews 3:16–19

These verses use a series of quick questions and answers, a common rhetorical method. The three questions follow the ideas in Psalm 95:8–11: The people of Israel rebelled against God, God was angry, and God swore they would never enter his rest. The answers come from other Old Testament passages about the Israelites' rebellion in the wilderness (Numbers 14; Deuteronomy 9; Psalm 106). The author emphasizes the severe consequences of disobeying God.

Hebrews 3:19

In Hebrews and the Old Testament, unbelief and disobedience are closely linked (Numbers 14:11; Deuteronomy 9:23; Psalm 78:22, 32). Because of their disobedience, they could not enter God's rest by entering the land of Canaan (Deuteronomy 3:20; 12:10; Joshua 1:13).

Hebrews 4:1

let us be careful: Fearing God means having a deep respect and awe for God and God's will. Missing out on God's promises would be a great tragedy.

Hebrews 4:1–2

The author moves to the promise that the faithful will enter God's rest and urges listeners to take this promise seriously. Hearing alone is not enough. Listening must be combined with faith.

Hebrews 4:2

- This good news is the message of salvation (Hebrews 2:3–4).
- They lacked the faith of those who listened to God. Some manuscripts say they didn't combine what they heard with faith. In both cases, the listeners had weak faith and did not trust God's promise.

Hebrews 4:3

- People who believe the good news are the true heirs of God's rest, which is the salvation offered through Christ's sacrifice.
- God has said: The quote from Psalm 95:11 reminds us that the unbelieving rebels in the wilderness would never enter God's place of rest (compare Hebrews 11:8, 10, 14–16; 12:22–24).
- since the foundation of the world: God's rest means much more than just entering Canaan (see study note on 4:4).

Hebrews 4:4

This verse quotes Genesis 2:2 to show that God created rest when he rested after creation.

Hebrews 4:5

This quote from Psalm 95:11 repeats the idea found in Hebrews 4:3.

Hebrews 4:6

it remains for some to enter His rest: Building on the discussion in Hebrews 4:3–5, the author will argue that the promised rest is still open (4:7–10). Those who wandered in the wilderness heard the good news that the promised land was open to them. They were not able to enter because they disobeyed God (see Numbers 14:1–25; Deuteronomy 1:19–46; Psalm 106).

Hebrews 4:7

God again designated a certain day as "Today,": David wrote Psalm 95 long after the events in the wilderness, so God's rest is not just for that earlier generation. The words from Psalm 95:7–8 urge us not to harden our hearts when we hear God's voice, so we can enter the rest that the people in the wilderness missed. This chance is available today (see Hebrews 3:13).

Hebrews 4:8

Joshua and Jesus share the same name (Greek Iēsous, Hebrew Yehoshuaʿ). In the Old Testament, it is usually translated as Joshua, and in the New Testament, as Jesus (see also study note on Exodus 17:9). The author is making a wordplay on their shared name. Joshua led God's people into the promised land (Joshua 3–4), but God meant more when he promised rest. Jesus provides God's ultimate rest (Hebrews 3:13–14; 4:3, 9–11, 14–16).

Hebrews 4:9

a Sabbath rest: The sacrifice of Jesus worked like a Day of Atonement sacrifice (Hebrews 5:1–3; 9:13–22; see Leviticus 23:26–28, 32). Through Christ's sacrifice, God's promised rest is available to his people.

Hebrews 4:10

- rests from his own work: See Exodus 20:8–11.
- just as God did: Genesis 2:2.

Hebrews 4:11

- make every effort to enter: If we do not actively obey God's voice and respond to the good news (Hebrews 4:1–2), we will face consequences like the wilderness wanderers did. We will fall.
- us ... no one: Obedience is not just a personal issue. God's people have a shared responsibility to obey and should support each other in this effort (compare 3:13; 10:25; 12:15).

Hebrews 4:12–13

The author urges us to listen to God's voice, as mentioned in Hebrews 3:7, 15, and 4:7, quoting Psalm 95:7. They describe God's word as alive and powerful, meaning it is an active and effective force. The word that created and controls the universe (Hebrews 1:2–3) can also strongly influence people. It is like the sharpest two-edged sword, able to reach the deepest parts of people's lives and reveal their thoughts and desires (see Ephesians 6:17; Revelation 1:16; 2:12, 16; 19:15).

Hebrews 4:13

Uncovered and exposed means feeling vulnerable, helpless, or unprotected. The guilty cannot hide from God's powerful judgment (see Revelation 3:17).

Hebrews 4:14

- This verse sums up the message and challenge of Hebrews. Jesus, the Son of God, is our high priest and the reason to stay strong in the Christian faith.
- a great high priest: Israel's high priest was the main leader in worship and the mediator between God and the people (see Exodus 31:10; Leviticus 4:3; 2 Kings 12:10; 2 Chronicles 26:20).
- who has passed through the heavens: Earthly high priests entered God's presence in the Most Holy Place once a year on the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 16:1–25). In contrast, Jesus, our high priest, has entered God's presence in heaven and stays there (Hebrews 7:26; 9:11–12, 23–26).
- let us hold firmly: Stay committed to actively believing in and being loyal to Jesus (see also Colossians 2:19; 2 Thessalonians 2:15; Revelation 2:13, 25; 3:11).

Hebrews 4:14–16

These important verses finish the encouragement that began at Hebrews 3:1. They also introduce a long teaching about Jesus and his role as high priest (4:14–10:25).

Hebrews 4:15

- Our high priest understands our weaknesses and our tendency to sin because he faced the same challenges. He was tempted by lust, greed, unfor-

giveness, and dishonesty. This makes him compassionate as our high priest (Hebrews 5:2).
- yet was without sin: Jesus is different from earthly high priests, who had to make offerings for their own sins before they could make offerings for the people (5:3; 7:26–28; see also 1 Peter 2:22–23).

Hebrews 4:16

- The verb translated as let us then approach can also mean "let us continually come," indicating ongoing action.
- As our compassionate high priest, Jesus has made it possible for people to confidently enter God's presence (see Hebrews 6:19–20; 10:19–23). There, we can receive his mercy and grace when we need it most.

Hebrews 5:1

- Every high priest: This phrase outlines what high priests must do.
- among men: The high priest was one of the people, so Jesus needed to become human (see Hebrews 2:17–18).
- Another requirement for high priests was to represent others by offering sacrifices for them (7:25–28). Only the high priest could offer the sacrifice on the Day of Atonement (Exodus 29; Leviticus 16:1–25).

Hebrews 5:1–10

This section discusses how the Son of God became a superior high priest. The main text is Psalm 110:4, where God promises that the Son will be a priest forever like Melchizedek.

Hebrews 5:2

A high priest could be kind to those who sin because he also had weaknesses, meaning he was sinful (Hebrews 5:3; compare 4:15).

Hebrews 5:3

On the Day of Atonement, the high priest had to offer sacrifices for himself and his family before offering sacrifices for the people (Leviticus 16:11).

Hebrews 5:4

God appoints the high priest, not humans (see Exodus 28:1; Leviticus 8:1–12; Numbers 16:1–26).

Hebrews 5:5–6

The author connects Psalms 2:7 and 110:4 because both passages feature God speaking to his Son. The exalted Son, who became human (Hebrews 1–2), is appointed by God to a special high priesthood.

Hebrews 5:7

The phrase with loud cries and tears likely refers to the suffering Jesus experienced in the garden of Gethsemane (see Matthew 26:36–46; Mark 14:32–42; Luke 22:40–46). God heard his prayers by affirming his righteousness and his role as high priest. Jesus showed faithful devotion to God. His example encourages the readers to remain faithful as well (compare Hebrews 12:2–3).

Hebrews 5:7–10

The suffering of Jesus was the basis for his higher role as a priest. His humiliation and suffering came before his rise to glory (Hebrews 2:9; Philippians 2:5–11).

Hebrews 5:8

He learned obedience through his suffering. Jesus was always obedient, even before his suffering. He lived his human life, including his death on the cross, fully submitting to God's will. We are expected to follow the same path (Hebrews 12:1–11).

Hebrews 5:9

- And having been made perfect: In Hebrews, perfect means "complete" or "mature" (see Hebrews 2:10; 5:14; 7:11; 9:9–11). Jesus became the source of eternal salvation for everyone who obeys him through his sufferings.
- As the Son obeyed the Father (5:8), fully following the Father's will, those seeking salvation must obey him.

Hebrews 5:10

high priest in the order of Melchizedek: See Hebrews 7:1–28 for more details.

Hebrews 5:11

dull of hearing: The Greek term means "slow, not very smart, careless, or lazy."

Hebrews 5:11–6.3

This message addresses the spiritual laziness of the recipients.

Hebrews 5:11–6.20

After starting to talk about the role of Jesus as high priest (Hebrews 5:1–10), the author addresses the audience with several encouragements (5:11–6:20). This change in the sermon or speech aimed to capture the listeners' attention.

Hebrews 5:12

- Their lack of spiritual energy was surprising because they had been believers for so long. They should have been spiritual leaders teaching others from their knowledge and Christian experience.
- the basic principles: The simplest parts of the Christian faith (see Hebrews 6:1–3).
- The imagery of milk and solid food was used to separate basic from advanced education, and immature from mature students.

Hebrews 5:14

Knowing the difference between right and wrong shows spiritual maturity.

Hebrews 6:1

- go on: Or let us be carried on, suggesting that God starts our growth to maturity (Philippians 2:12–13) and that it is a continuous journey.
- Repentance and faith are the fundamental commitments that introduce a person to the new covenant and form the basic stance of a Christian's life (see Acts 20:21).

Hebrews 6:1–3

Because the hearers' are not mature (Hebrews 5:11–14), the author encourages them to go beyond basic teachings. These six basic teachings were fundamental parts of Jewish instruction. The author may be urging them to deepen their understanding of Christ, which he explains further in 7:1–10:25.

Hebrews 6:2

- The term baptisms (or washings) is plural, indicating it means more than just Christian baptism. In first-century Judaism, teachings about different washings were common (see Matthew 15:2; Mark 7:3). The author might also refer to the cleansing rituals from the Old Testament (compare Hebrews 9:13; 10:22).
- The laying on of hands was linked to:
- healing (Mark 5:22–23; Luke 13:13),
- ritual blessing (Matthew 19:13, 15), r
- eceiving the Holy Spirit (Acts 8:17; 9:17; 19:6), and
- recognizing a person's ministry (Acts 6:6; 13:3).
- Resurrection of the dead: See "The Resurrection of the Dead" Theme Note.
- eternal judgment: See Revelation 20:11–15.

Hebrews 6:3

The author is encouraging readers to grow up, not just in understanding but in all aspects (see Hebrews 4:11; 5:14; 10:23–39; 12:1–13).

Hebrews 6:4

- In Greek, the word translated impossible starts the sentence for emphasis. It means this absolutely cannot happen (see also Hebrews 6:18; 10:4; 11:6).
- They were once enlightened when they "first learned about Christ" (see 10:32 and corresponding study note).
- The good things of heaven might refer to the manna given from heaven (Exodus 16:4, 15; Psalm 78:24) as a symbol of spiritual blessings.

Hebrews 6:4–8

This passage is one of the most challenging in the New Testament. It warns about those who have abandoned the Christian faith. Those who have turned away from Christ and the church are like those who fell in the wilderness (Hebrews 3:15–19). Their lack of faith leads to severe judgment (compare 10:26–31).

Hebrews 6:5

- who have tasted the goodness of the word of God: These people heard God's word preached (Hebrews 2:3–4; 4:1–2) and saw its impact.
- the powers of the coming age: They witnessed signs and wonders when they heard the good news (2:4; compare Exodus 7:3–4; Deuteronomy 7:19; Psalms 66:3; 77:15–20; 78:9–16; 1 Corinthians 10:1–13).

Hebrews 6:6

- then have fallen away: This image reminds us of the people in the wilderness who disobeyed God and perished in the desert (Hebrews 3:17; 4:11; Numbers 14:1–4, 29–30).
- to be restored to repentance: They had repented before but showed no results from it (Hebrews 6:7–8). When people reject Christ and his ultimate sacrifice, they cannot find another way to repent.
- Rejecting the Son of God is like nailing him to the cross again. Crucifixion was the worst form of rejection and shame in the Greco-Roman world. Those who turned away from Christ were like those who mocked him at the cross, denying he was the Messiah and Son of God, and instead deserving of shame (see Matthew 27:39–44).

Hebrews 6:7–8

land: Fertile land symbolizes blessing, while barren land with thorns and thistles represents a curse. Burning such a field symbolizes judgment (2 Samuel 23:4–7; Isaiah 10:17; 33:12; Ezekiel 19:12–13; Matthew 3:10).

Hebrews 6:9

- we are convinced: Skilled speakers and writers show confidence in their audience to inspire them (see Romans 15:14).
- The author believes his hearers' lives show they truly know God, including their salvation. In the New Testament, salvation mainly refers to Christ's work on the cross (Hebrews 5:9–10; see also study note on 2:3). Hebrews highlights the completion of salvation at the end of time (9:28).

Hebrews 6:9–12

After giving a strong warning to his hearers (Hebrews 6:4–8), the author now softens it by calling them beloved. He shows confidence in them and offers more encouragement.

Hebrews 6:10

He will not forget your work: By showing love for God and his people, your actions prove your true connection with God (Romans 2:6–7; 1 Corinthians 3:13–15; James 2:14–20). God remembers (Exodus 2:24; 1 Chronicles 16:15; Psalm 106:45) and recognizes those who truly belong to him.

Hebrews 6:11

show this same diligence (literally show the same eager commitment): Loving other believers is a key sign of true Christian faith (James 2:15–16; 1 John 3:16–20). By being diligent and committed, they can be sure of their hope in Christ. Perseverance brings assurance of salvation.

Hebrews 6:12

A strong commitment (Hebrews 6:10–11) helps prevent spiritual dullness (5:11–12). By loving God and others, we follow the example of great faith leaders. The author stresses that faith and endurance are essential for God's people (see 11:4–38).

Hebrews 6:13–14

Abraham was a leading example of faith. He believed God would give him a son and was ready to sacrifice that son to obey God (Hebrews 11:17–19; Genesis 15:1–5; 22:1–14). Because of Abraham's faith, God promised to bless him and increase his descendants.

Hebrews 6:13–20

This passage highlights how we can trust God's promises. It uses an example (Hebrews 6:13–15), then explains a general rule (6:16), and finally makes the main point: God made an important promise (6:17–18). This promise gives us hope because it shows Jesus is our eternal high priest (6:19–20).

Hebrews 6:15

God promised to make Abraham a great nation through Isaac (Exodus 1:7).

Hebrews 6:16

- In human relationships, when people take an oath, it is considered binding. If oaths assure truth among humans, an oath from God should inspire even more confidence (Hebrews 6:17–19).
- someone greater than themselves: Compare with 6:13.

Hebrews 6:17–18

- God also made a promise with an oath (a solemn promise), see Hebrews 7:20–22. This oath shows that God will never change his mind because it is impossible for God to lie (see Psalm 110:4).
- We who have fled to take hold of the hope set before us, similiar to people in the Old Testament who accidentally killed someone and sought refuge (Numbers 35:9–34; Deuteronomy 4:41–43). Christ is like a city of refuge, where believers find safety from God's anger. Because of this, Christ's followers have great confidence.

Hebrews 6:19–20

- Christian hope is a reliable anchor for our souls. In the first century, an anchor symbolized stability and safety.
- behind the curtain: A curtain separated the outer room of the sanctuary, where only priests could enter, from the inner room, the Most Holy Place (Exodus 25:10–40). Only the high priest could enter the Most Holy Place, and only once a year on the Day of Atonement (Exodus 29; Leviticus 16:1–25). Because of Jesus and his unique role as high priest, he has already entered God's presence for us. He serves as our eternal high priest and leads us to enter God's presence with him (Hebrews 10:19–23).
- the order of Melchizedek: This phrase introduces the discussion in 7:1–28.

Hebrews 7:1

- king of Salem: See Genesis 14:18 and the related study note.
- and priest of God Most High: Melchizedek was both a king and a priest, unlike the Hebrew kings. This role foreshadowed the Messiah.
- returning from the slaughter of the kings: See Genesis 14:1–17.

Hebrews 7:1–10

This section proclaims the superiority of Melchizedek's priesthood over that of the Levites, based primarily on Genesis 14:17–20.

Hebrews 7:1–28

Hebrews 7 expands on the idea from 5:1–10: Jesus is chosen as a high priest like Melchizedek.

Hebrews 7:2

- Abraham gave a tenth to the Lord by giving it to Melchizedek, his priest. This act foreshadows the giving of tithes under the law (Leviticus 27:30, 32) and is important in the author's argument (Hebrews 7:4).
- Melchi- (Hebrew melek) means king.
- -zedek (Hebrew tsedeq) means justice or righteousness.
- Salem (Hebrew shalom) means peace. Rabbis often highlighted the theological meaning of a biblical figure's name by linking it to other Hebrew terms.

Hebrews 7:3

- We have no record of Melchizedek's family, which is important because the Levitical priesthood required ancestry. He seems to appear from nowhere, as if his life has no beginning or end. The author interprets Genesis 14:17–20 with Psalm 110:4, seeing Melchizedek as symbolizing an eternal priesthood.
- He remains a priest forever, unlike a Levite whose priesthood ends at death (Hebrews 7:8, 23).
- like the Son of God: Melchizedek was not an Old Testament appearance of Jesus. Instead, his priesthood and the priesthood of Jesus share similar traits, as noted in Psalm 110:4.

Hebrews 7:4

This section (Hebrews 7:1–10) asks us to think about how important Melchizedek was by comparing him to Levi's descendants. Melchizedek was so significant that Abraham gave him a tenth of the battle spoils (Genesis 14:20).

Hebrews 7:5–6

- Collecting the tithe was both a duty and an honor for the priests under the law of Moses (Numbers 18:21–32).
- from the people: This refers to all the people of Israel.
- Although Melchizedek was not a descendant of Levi, he collected a tenth from Abraham, the ancestor of the Levites. This shows Melchizedek's greater status over both Abraham and his descendants, including the priests (Hebrews 7:8–10).

Hebrews 7:6–7

Melchizedek blessed Abraham (Genesis 14:19–20). This blessing is like one a superior gives to a subordinate, such as a father blessing his son or a priest blessing his people (Genesis 49:1–28; Numbers 6:22–27). The ability to give a blessing shows that Melchizedek is greater than Abraham.

Hebrews 7:8

One reason Melchizedek is greater than the Levites is his "immortality" (7:3). The Levites were men who died, but Scripture says Melchizedek continues to live.

Hebrews 7:9–10

And so to speak: The author knows that saying the Levites paid a tithe to Melchizedek is not literally true, since Levi was not born yet. Abraham represented all his descendants when he paid his tithe to Melchizedek. Levi was connected to Abraham because he came from Abraham's lineage. All of Abraham's descendants were united with him. So, his action could be seen as their action.

Hebrews 7:11

In the Letter to the Hebrews, perfection means achieving a desired goal rather than being flawless (see study note on 5:9). The priesthood under the old covenant could not fulfill all of God's intentions for a covenant relationship with his people. This is why God needed to create a different priesthood.

Hebrews 7:11–28

After explaining why Melchizedek is greater than the Levites (Hebrews 7:1–10), the author now argues that Jesus, our high priest like Melchizedek, is also greater than the Levitical priests of the old covenant.

Hebrews 7:12

According to the law given to Moses, the appointed priests were descendants of Aaron (Exodus 28:41–43;

29:9). The priesthood changed because Jesus is now the high priest. So, God changed the law about priests.

Hebrews 7:13–14

belonged to a different tribe: Under the old covenant, priests came from the tribe of Levi, but Jesus was from the tribe of Judah.

Hebrews 7:15–17

This change in how God appoints priests (Hebrews 7:11–14) is clear through Jesus being appointed as a different kind of priest. Like Melchizedek, Jesus is a priest forever. His resurrection from the dead shows he has the power of an indestructible life. Since his priesthood, in the order of Melchizedek, is superior to the Levites' (7:1–10), he replaces them as priest.

Hebrews 7:18

- The previous rule for becoming a priest was being part of Aaron's family (see Exodus 28:41–43).
- set aside: See Hebrews 7:15–17.
- because it was weak and useless: This is explained in the following verses (7:19–28).

Hebrews 7:19

the law made nothing perfect: The law could not completely remove sin or guarantee eternal salvation. God achieved these things through the superior high priesthood of Jesus.

Because of this, believers have confidence in a better hope and a restored relationship with God. They can draw near to God without fear of condemnation.

Hebrews 7:19–28

The priests under the old covenant were weak because they died, which ended their service, and they were also sinful. In contrast, Jesus is the new high priest. He never sinned and he defeated death, so his priesthood is permanent and more effective.

Hebrews 7:20–21

- This new system is about how God chooses a priest.
- God's serious promise is shown in the quote from Psalm 110:4.

Hebrews 7:22

In legal terms, a guarantee means taking responsibility for another person's debt or obligation. The guarantor accepts the risk if the other person fails.

Because God confirmed this promise with an oath, Jesus has a priesthood that cannot be challenged or undone. As a result, our covenant relationship with God is secure. Having Jesus as the guarantee makes the new covenant better.

Hebrews 7:23–24

The old covenant needed many priests because each one eventually died. In contrast, the priesthood of Jesus is permanent. This term refers to something unchangeable, like the sun's daily path across the sky or the regular change of seasons.

Hebrews 7:25

- able to save completely: Since Jesus lives forever, the salvation he offers also lasts forever. To approach an eternal God, we need an eternal priest.
- Jesus will intercede or appeal to God for us as our high priest of the new covenant, and his intercession never ends (see Hebrews 9:11–28; 10:21–22; Romans 8:31–34).

Hebrews 7:26–27

- Jesus is free from sin and different from sinners (see Hebrews 4:15). This makes him better than the old covenant priests, who had to handle their own sins and those of the people (see also 5:1–3).
- He holds the highest place of honor in heaven, affirming his unique role as high priest (see 2:9; 5:9; Philippians 2:5–11).
- once for all: This means once, never to be repeated, not once for all people.

Hebrews 7:28

- This verse summarizes the discussion in 5:1–3 about Christ's role as High Priest (5:1–10; 7:1–28).
- Limited by human weakness refers primarily to human sinfulness and mortality.
- God appointed his Son, Jesus, with an oath (see Psalm 110:4, which is important for understanding Hebrews 7:11–28).
- In Hebrews, the term perfect means complete or mature (see 2:10; 5:9; 7:11; 9:9–11); the Son, through his sacrificial death and resurrection, has become completely qualified to serve as our eternal High Priest, and his priesthood lasts forever.

Hebrews 8:1–2

- The first two verses of chapter 8 connect the previous discussion and introduce the next topic.
- The main point is that Jesus is appointed as a superior high priest (Hebrews 5:1–10; 7:1–28).

- He serves in the heavenly tabernacle (also in 8:5): This introduces the theme of Jesus's superior offering, discussed in the rest of this section (8:3–10:18). Unlike the Levitical priests who served in an earthly tent or building, the sacrifice of Jesus is superior because he serves in the true place of worship, the very presence of God in heaven (8:5; 9:11, 24; 10:12).

Hebrews 8:1–10.18

This passage explains that the role of Jesus as the heavenly high priest is better than the role of earthly priests.

Hebrews 8:3

- Every high priest must offer gifts and sacrifices. Since offering sacrifices is a general duty of priests, Jesus also needed to offer a sacrifice.
- This verse repeats what was mentioned in the first verse of the earlier discussion (Hebrews 5:1), marking another important section in the book.

Hebrews 8:4

If Jesus were on earth, he would not be a priest under the old system (see Hebrews 7:13–14). However, Jesus is in heaven, making his priestly role unique and better than the priests of the old covenant (8:5; 9:11, 24; 10:12).

Hebrews 8:5

a copy and shadow: The earthly place of worship was a copy of the real one in heaven. This is why God told Moses to follow the pattern (see Exodus 25:40; 26:30; compare Acts 7:44). Both Judaism and early Christianity talked about a heavenly temple in a heavenly Jerusalem, which would come to earth at the end of time (see Revelation 21:2). Hebrews suggests that God showed Moses this heavenly place so he could build the earthly tabernacle. However, Jesus serves as high priest in the heavenly temple.

Hebrews 8:6

- He mediates: A mediator helps two parties reach an agreement. Christ's sacrifice created a covenant (agreement) between people and God.
- the covenant He mediates is better: See "The New Covenant" Theme Note. This covenant is better because it relies on better promises (see Hebrews 8:7–13).

Hebrews 8:7

The first agreement, made at Mount Sinai, was not without faults. It was only part of God's plan, because it did not overcome human weakness (see Hebrews 7:11–28; 8:9).

Hebrews 8:7–13

The author refers to Jeremiah 31:31–34, an Old Testament prophecy about the new covenant with several important promises. Highlighting the new covenant's superiority supports the argument in Hebrews 9:1–10:18 that the Son's offering under the new covenant was better than the old covenant offerings.

Hebrews 8:8

God found fault with the people: The people could not follow the old agreement's terms (see study note on Hebrews 8:7), so God created a new agreement.

Hebrews 8:9

- God made a covenant with their ancestors at Sinai (Exodus 19:1–8; 24:7–8; 34:27–28; Deuteronomy 4:13).
- I took them by the hand: God rescued his people from Egypt, guiding them like a parent guides a child who cannot care for itself (see Exodus 12–14).
- they did not abide by My covenant: See Hebrews 3:7–19; Numbers 14:1–38; Deuteronomy 9; Psalms 106.
- I disregarded them: The covenant warned that if the people turned away, God would also turn away from them (see Deuteronomy 28:15–68; 30:11–20; 1 Kings 8:22–53; 2 Chronicles 6:12–42).

Hebrews 8:10

In the old covenant, people had to deeply understand the words of the law (Deuteronomy 32:46). The kings of Israel and Judah were judged on their dedication to God's law (2 Kings 10:31; 2 Chronicles 31:21). Under the new covenant, God's laws are meant to be in people's minds and hearts. People would have renewed hearts and minds, with God's law as a natural, internal motivation.

Hebrews 8:11

All people in the new covenant know the Lord. A close and personal relationship with him is at the center of the new covenant.

Hebrews 8:12

A key feature of the new covenant is that God will forgive their wickedness and never again remember their sins. The sacrifice of Jesus fully cleanses his people from sin (Hebrews 9:13–15; 10:14–18, 22; 1 John 1:7).

Hebrews 8:13

The word new in "new" covenant emphasizes that, after God established this covenant, the Sinai covenant became old or obselete. Its usefulness ended, and it was about to be replaced.

Hebrews 9:1–5

These verses describe the tabernacle, which was Israel's place of worship before they built the temple.

Hebrews 9:1–10.18

This section explains that Christ's death, as the sacrifice in the new covenant, is better than the sacrifices in the old covenant. In Hebrews 9:1–10, the author describes worship practices under the old covenant rules (see Exodus 28–29; Leviticus 1–10; 16:1–17:16). In Hebrews 9:11–10:18, these rules are compared to Christ's superior offering.

Hebrews 9:2

- Israel's tabernacle was a tent with two rooms (see Exodus 25–31; 35:1–40:38).
- the lampstand: Exodus 25:31–40; 26:35.
- the table: Exodus 25:23–30.
- The priests entered the Holy Place daily to perform their ritual duties (Hebrews 9:6; see Exodus 28:43; Numbers 28:3–8).

Hebrews 9:3

At the back of the first room of the tabernacle was a curtain that separated it from the second room, called the Most Holy Place (Exodus 26:31–33). This curtain was a sacred barrier. Only the high priest could go behind it into the Most Holy Place, and only once a year on the Day of Atonement (Hebrews 9:7; see Exodus 30:6, 10; Leviticus 16:2–34; 23:27–32).

Hebrews 9:4

- The gold incense altar likely stood just outside the inner curtain (Exodus 30:1–10). Its exact location is unclear in the Old Testament, but it was closely linked to the Most Holy Place (Exodus 30:6; Leviticus 16:13; 1 Kings 6:22).
- The ark of the covenant, representing God's presence, was the most important item in the tabernacle (see Exodus 25:10–22).
- The gold jar with manna reminded people of God's provision in the wilderness (Exodus 16:32–34).
- Aaron's staff, which sprouted leaves (see Numbers 17:1–11), reminded people not to rebel against God's chosen leaders (Numbers 17:10; compare Hebrews 13:17).
- The stone tablets of the covenant held the Ten Commandments and reminded the people of the rules they were to live by (Exodus 25:16; 31:18; Deuteronomy 9:9–10:5).

Hebrews 9:5

- The cherubim of divine glory were angel statues on the cover of the ark. These angels are closely linked to God's glorious presence (Genesis 3:24; Psalms 80:1; 99:1; Isaiah 37:16). The ark's cover was the atonement place, where they sprinkled blood from the Day of Atonement sacrifice (Leviticus 16:14–16).
- we cannot discuss these things in detail now: The main topic is the offering of sacrifices under the old covenant (Hebrews 9:6–10).

Hebrews 9:6–8

In the Holy Place, which was the first room of the tabernacle (Hebrews 9:2), priests had specific duties. They kept the lamps burning and replaced the sacred loaves of bread regularly (Exodus 27:20–21; Leviticus 24:8).

Hebrews 9:7

Each year on the Day of Atonement, the high priest offered sacrifices for sins not covered by other sacrifices from the past year (Leviticus 16:1–25).

Hebrews 9:8

- had not yet been disclosed: Under the old covenant system, people could not freely enter God's presence.
- The outer room of the tabernacle, which served as a sacred barrier, kept people from entering the Most Holy Place. This barrier symbolized the entire system, which kept people away from God's presence instead of guiding them into it.

Hebrews 9:9

This example shows that the gifts and sacrifices of the old covenant could not clear people's consciences. They could not remove guilt before a holy God (see 9:14; 10:2, 22; 13:18).

Hebrews 9:10

The old system focused only on physical rules and could not address people's inner feelings (Hebrews 8:10; 10:21–24). It was temporary, meant to last until Christ came to create a better system (9:11–10:18).

Hebrews 9:11

- Christ is now the high priest over all the good things of the new covenant. God appointed him, as mentioned in Psalm 110:4 (Hebrews 5:1–10; 7:1–28), and he offered a better sacrifice.
- that have come: Some manuscripts say that are about to come, either from the old covenant's viewpoint or looking forward to God's future plan.
- Christ's sacrifice is better because it was made in the greater, perfect tabernacle in heaven, not the earthly one (see 8:5 and corresponding study note).

Hebrews 9:11–10.18

The author compares the old system (Hebrews 9:1–10) with Christ's superior sacrifice as high priest. Christ offered his own blood, not animal blood (9:13–22; see also 9:7). His offering took place in the heavenly tabernacle, not the earthly one (9:23–24; see also 9:1–5). Unlike repeated offerings, Christ's sacrifice happened only once (9:25–10:18; see also 7:27; 9:6–7).

Hebrews 9:12

- Christ's offering is better because he used his own blood, not the blood of goats and calves (see Leviticus 16:3–5).
- Christ's offering is better because he entered the Most Holy Place once for all time. Unlike the sacrifices in the old covenant, which had to be repeated every year (Hebrews 10:1), the sacrificial death of Jesus was needed only once and secured our redemption forever.

Hebrews 9:13

The ashes of a young cow were mixed with water to purify people from ceremonial impurity (see Numbers 19).

Hebrews 9:14

- how much more: This is an argument from lesser to greater, a traditional Jewish way of reasoning. The idea is that if something is true in a smaller case, it is even more true in a bigger case (see also Hebrews 2:1–4; 12:25–29). If animal blood had some effect in cleansing, then Christ's blood will be much more effective.
- purify our consciences: Christ's sacrifice, unlike the old covenant sacrifices, removes the guilt that keeps us from God by thoroughly cleansing us from sinful actions.

Hebrews 9:15

the mediator: This term describes a person who helps resolve a tough legal or political disagreement. In the old covenant, people saw Moses and the angels as go-betweens between God and the people (Galatians 3:19–20). In the new covenant, Christ connects God and people through his sacrificial death (Hebrews 8:6; 12:24; Romans 6:23; 1 Timothy 2:5; 1 Peter 3:18) and ongoing intercession (prayer on behalf of others) (Hebrews 7:25).

Hebrews 9:16–22

The author explains a basic rule about wills or covenants (Hebrews 9:16–17). He then discusses it further, using the start of the first covenant as an example (9:18–22).

Hebrews 9:18–19

- put into effect: Exodus 24:3–8 describes Moses starting the old covenant using the blood of a sacrifice.
- Hebrews is the only ancient source that says Moses sprinkled the book of God's law (see Exodus 24:6–8).
- Hyssop branches have blue flowers and strong-smelling leaves. People used them with sacrifices for cleansing (Exodus 12:22; Leviticus 14:4; Numbers 19:6, 18).

Hebrews 9:20

"This is the blood of the covenant that the LORD has made with you" (Exodus 24:8): Jesus used similar words at the Last Supper, talking about his own death (Matthew 26:28; Mark 14:24; 1 Corinthians 11:25).

Hebrews 9:21

he sprinkled with blood: See Exodus 24:3–8 and Leviticus 16:14–19.

Hebrews 9:22

In the law of Moses, many cleansing rituals required the death of a sacrificial animal. Blood was used in these cleansing rituals (see Exodus 29:12; 30:10; Leviticus 4:6, 17; 16:14–19; Numbers 19:4) and for making atonement (see Leviticus 16). The shedding of Christ's blood created the new covenant, offering lasting purification and complete forgiveness of sins (Hebrews 8:12; 10:15–18; Matthew 26:28; Ephesians 1:7).

Hebrews 9:23

- This verse uses a comparison from lesser to greater (see study note on Hebrews 9:14). Just as heaven is greater than the earthly tabernacle, Christ's sacrifice had to be much better than earthly sacrifices.

- So it was necessary: See 9:16–22; Leviticus 16:14–19.
- copies of the heavenly things: See study note on Hebrews 8:5.
- heavenly things to be purified: Just as the tabernacle needed cleansing because of the Israelites' sin (Leviticus 16:16–19), the heavenly tabernacle required removing uncleanness from those entering heaven under the new covenant.

Hebrews 9:24

Under the new covenant, Christ did not offer his sacrifice in the earthly tabernacle. Instead, he entered God's presence in heaven to act for us. His sacrifice makes him a better mediator to help us have a right relationship with God (2 Corinthians 5:19–21).

Hebrews 9:25–26

Under the old covenant, the priests had to repeat the sacrifice on the Day of Atonement every year (Leviticus 16:29–34). Christ's better sacrifice was made once and for all time.

Hebrews 9:26

Otherwise: The author uses a logical argument to show that Christ's one sacrifice is permanently effective. Christ is both the sacrifice and the high priest. If his offering had to be repeated every year, like the earthly priests, he would have to die again and again. But that idea is absurd. Clearly, Christ died once for all time to take away sin.

Hebrews 9:27–28

Christ's first coming was to remove the sins of many people. When he comes again, it will not be to address sins, as that is already done. Instead, he will bring salvation to everyone eagerly waiting for him (see study note on Galatians 5:5).

Hebrews 10:1

The old system under the law of Moses (literally the law), like the tabernacle itself (Hebrews 8:5), was just a shadow, a dim preview of a greater reality—the good things that Christ started in the new covenant. Under the old covenant, sacrifices had to be repeated many times because they could not permanently cleanse worshipers or allow them to be in God's presence forever.

Hebrews 10:2

- The ongoing sacrifices show they were not enough. If the old covenant sacrifices had provided lasting purity, they would have ended.
- Their guilt would have disappeared: See Hebrews 9:9, 14; 10:22; 13:18.

Hebrews 10:3

Instead of removing guilt, the ongoing sacrifices actually reminded those who wished to come near to God, year after year, that they were guilty before God.

Hebrews 10:4

The sacrifices of bulls and goats in the old covenant provided some cleansing (Hebrews 9:13, 23), but it was limited. They could not remove sins completely. These sacrifices could not permanently cleanse or bring lasting peace with God (see Acts 10:36; Romans 5:1; 11:26–27).

Hebrews 10:5

but a body You prepared for Me: God had prepared the psalm writer to obey and be ready to do God's will. Hebrews now applies this idea to Christ. For Hebrews, preparing a human body, especially Christ's body, shows that God would use it as a better sacrifice.

Hebrews 10:5–7

These verses quote Psalm 40:6–8. Psalm 40 is a song praising God, where the writer expresses a wish to follow God's will. The author of Hebrews sees Christ as the one speaking.

Hebrews 10:8–10

- The author of Hebrews carefully follows the order of thought in the psalm.
- In the passage above He says, "Sacrifices and offerings, burnt offerings and sin offerings You did not desire…": The author of Hebrews sees this as God rejecting the old system of sacrifices.
- Then He adds, "Here I am, I have come to do Your will.": The author of Hebrews interprets this as Christ's willingness to be the ultimate sacrifice for sins.
- The author of Hebrews concludes that because of Christ's sacrifice, God has canceled the first covenant. God's plan, as shown by Psalm 40:6–8, was for Christ to die for sins as a sacrifice, and this only needed to happen once for all time.

Hebrews 10:11

- every priest stands: See Deuteronomy 18:5.
- Day after day: For example, see 2 Chronicles 13:11.

Hebrews 10:11–14

Christ's sacrifice was greater and final. This was different from the repeated sacrifices made by the priests under the old covenant.

Hebrews 10:12–13

- Christ's sacrifice was different from that of the earthly high priests. He offered himself to God, rather than offering animal sacrifices.
- After his sacrifice, Christ sat in a place of honor (see Psalm 110:1). Unlike the old covenant priests who stood daily (Hebrews 10:11), he waits until his enemies are humbled and become a footstool under his feet (Psalm 110:1).

Hebrews 10:14

- made perfect: See study notes on Hebrews 7:11, 28.
- those who are being sanctified: This means being fully purified from sins.

Hebrews 10:15–17

- The author again quotes from Jeremiah 31:33–34 (see Hebrews 8:7–12) to support the statement in 10:14. This shows that Christ's one sacrifice under the new covenant has made worshipers perfect forever.
- God's laws have now been placed in their hearts and on their minds. This means that a believer's relationship with God is now inward, not just outward.
- Their sins and lawless acts I will remember no more: As the author has shown in 9:11–10:14, this is possible only because Christ's sacrifice is greater than all others.

Hebrews 10:18

When God completely and permanently forgives sins (Hebrews 10:1–4, 11), there is no need for more sacrifices. Christ's superior sacrifice has made the old covenant's sacrificial system unnecessary.

Hebrews 10:19

The earthly Most Holy Place was not open to everyone (see study note on Hebrews 9:3). Now, however, God's presence in heaven (9:11, 24) is accessible because of the sacrificial death of Jesus (9:11–10:18).

Hebrews 10:19–25

The author of Hebrews repeats words and ideas from Hebrews 4:14–16 to highlight and summarize the main section (4:14–10:18). This also introduces the advice that follows. The message of Hebrews is clear: The new covenant, established by the superior work of Jesus, provides a better foundation for approaching God and staying strong in the Christian faith.

Hebrews 10:20

The death of Jesus has created a new and life-giving path for us through the curtain. This refers to the curtain that separated the first and second rooms of the tabernacle (see Hebrews 9:1–5). Believers may now enter the Most Holy Place of God's presence because of the sacrificial death of Jesus.

Hebrews 10:21

Jesus, as Messiah, is the high priest and king who leads God's people (see Hebrews 3:1–6; 2 Samuel 7:13).

Hebrews 10:22

- sincere heart: Under the new covenant, believers have changed hearts (Hebrews 8:10; 10:16; Jer 31:31–34).
- in full assurance of faith: Christ's actions for us give us confidence that God will welcome us.
- having our hearts sprinkled to cleanse us from a guilty conscience: Christ's sacrificial death has completely cleansed us from sin (see 9:13–14, 19–23).

Hebrews 10:23

We should firmly hold on to the hope we affirm, that Christ's death helps us have a right relationship with God.

Hebrews 10:24

True Christian commitment is shown through acts of love and good deeds (Hebrews 6:10; 10:32–34; Galatians 5:13; 1 Thessalonians 1:3; Revelation 2:19).

Hebrews 10:25

- Some people in this Christian community had started to skip their regular worship meetings, possibly to avoid persecution (Hebrews 10:32–39).
- We should encourage each other to love and do good deeds, keeping in mind the day of Christ's return, his second coming (9:28; Luke 12:42–46; 1 Corinthians 5:5; 1 Thessalonians 5:2; 2 Peter 3:10; 1 John 2:28).

Hebrews 10:26–27

deliberately: Open rebellion against God's laws was called "sinning with a high hand" (see study note on Numbers 15:30–31). Here, the author refers to rejecting Christ and his work. Christ's sacrifice for sins ended the old covenant's sacrificial system (Hebrews 9:11–10:18). If someone rejects the Son's sacrifice, there is

no other sacrifice for forgiveness. A person who rejects Christ can only expect judgment as one of God's enemies (compare Isaiah 26:10–11).

Hebrews 10:26–31

The author gives a strong warning about the danger of rejecting God's Son and his message. This warning urges listeners to commit to following Christ.

Hebrews 10:28–29

- The author compares two situations, one less severe and one more severe (see study note on Hebrews 9:14). The less severe situation is the old punishment of death for someone who refused to follow the law of Moses (see Deuteronomy 13:6–11). The more severe situation involves those who reject Christ and show him disrespect.
- How much more severely do you think one deserves to be punished: Eternal damnation awaits those who have rejected Christ.
- The blood of the covenant, which made us holy, is Christ's perfect sacrifice (9:11–10:18).
- insulted the Spirit of grace: Those who reject the Spirit's guidance and mercy deny the truth of the good news and the greatness of Christ and his saving work (compare Mark 3:22–30).

Hebrews 10:30–31

- "The Lord will judge His people": Deuteronomy 32:36; compare 1 Peter 4:17–18.
- That God will repay them and will judge His people shows how serious the situation is for those who have rejected Christ. Once God decides to judge someone, no one can save that person from God's hand (Deuteronomy 32:39).

Hebrews 10:32

the early days that you were in the light: The author reminds his audience about the early days after they believed in Christ. During that time, their faith was tested. Even when they suffered greatly, they stayed faithful. Suffering is normal for someone who identifies with Christ and his community (see 13:12–13; Acts 9:16; Romans 8:17; 1 Corinthians 4:12–13; Philippians 1:29; James 1:2–4).

Hebrews 10:32–39

After the harsh warning in Hebrews 10:26–31, there is a message of encouragement. The listeners are reminded of their past faithfulness as a positive example to follow now.

Hebrews 10:33

- publicly exposed to ridicule: They were insulted and shamed.
- persecution: They were physically abused.
- Sometimes they were directly abused, and other times they supported others who were suffering.

Hebrews 10:34

- Those who were put in jail depended on friends and family for basic needs (see Hebrews 13:3).
- the confiscation of your property: The Roman government sometimes forced people out of their homes and cities (see Acts 18:2–3). These Christians had experienced this persecution before and accepted it with joy (see Romans 5:3; James 1:2–4; 1 Peter 1:6). They looked forward to better things that will last forever (see Hebrews 11:35). God promises rewards to those who stay faithful.

Hebrews 10:35–36

Because of their strong faith in the past (Hebrews 10:32–34), the author encourages them not to lose their trust in the Lord. The term translated as confidence also refers to boldness when approaching God (4:16; 10:19; see also 3:6). Those who stay faithful will receive a great reward (see 1:14; 6:12; 9:15; James 1:12). Patient endurance is crucial when facing persecution, as the author explains in Hebrews 10:32–12:17.

Hebrews 10:37–38

These verses quote Habakkuk 2:3–4 to show the difference between the righteous and the wicked when they face God's judgment (see also Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11).

Hebrews 10:39

The author concludes this section by expressing confidence in the listeners (see study note on Hebrews 6:9).

Hebrews 11:1

- Before sharing examples, the author explains faith: It means acting on what God has shown about his will and character.
- Our faith is based on the reality that God keeps his promises.

Hebrews 11:1–40

Chapter 11 gives a long list of people who trusted God. This shows clearly that living by faith is the only true way to follow God. The writer keeps repeating the words "by faith" to make this message clear. Each example follows the same pattern:

- (a) the phrase by faith,
- (b) the person's name,
- (c) the event or action showing faith, and
- (d) the result.

Hebrews 11:2

the ancients were commended: Scripture speaks positively about their lives of faith (see also Hebrews 11:39).

Hebrews 11:3

The belief that God created the entire universe is fundamental to Jewish and Christian theology (see Genesis 1:1–3). God made everything we see today. A faithful life believes that, like creation, God's promises are real and will become reality, even if they are not visible now.

Hebrews 11:4

- Abel: See Genesis 4:3–5.
- By faith he was commended as righteous: Compare with Hebrews 10:38.
- he still speaks: The story of his faith challenges us, and his blood testifies to his righteousness and the injustice of his murder (see 12:24).

Hebrews 11:5

- Enoch went to heaven and did not face a normal death (see Genesis 5:21–24).
- "He could not be found, because God had taken him away.": Genesis 5:24.

Hebrews 11:6

- without faith it is impossible to please God: The author refers to Hebrews 10:38, which quotes Habakkuk 2:4.
- Faith must include believing that God exists and that he rewards those who sincerely seek him. When life is difficult, listeners are encouraged to trust God and expect him to fulfill his promises.

Hebrews 11:7

- The story of Noah (see Genesis 6:1–9:17) shows that faith means obeying even when you cannot see the outcome.
- things not yet seen: Specifically, the flood. Noah's faith showed the world God's truth and his wish for holiness.

Hebrews 11:8

Abraham ... obeyed: See Genesis 12:1–2. He acted without knowing his destination, trusting in what he could not yet see.

Hebrews 11:9–10

- By faith he dwelt in the promised land: Abraham did not receive the promised land. Instead, he lived like a foreigner in tents (see Genesis 12:10–13:18).
- as did Isaac and Jacob: This faith continued with the next two generations. They received the same promise and trusted God but did not see it fulfilled.
- the city with foundations: Abraham did not settle in Canaanite cities. He followed God's will, looking forward to a heavenly city.

Hebrews 11:12

- and he as good as dead: Abraham, who was very old, became the ancestor of an entire nation. Faith means believing that God can fulfill his promises, even when it seems impossible.
- as the stars ... and the sand: See Genesis 22:17. God kept his promise (Exodus 1:7).

Hebrews 11:13

Abraham's family lived in the promised land as foreigners and wanderers (see Genesis 23:4; compare 1 Chronicles 29:15; Psalm 39:12; 1 Peter 2:11).

Hebrews 11:13–16

The author stops to explain the common lessons seen in the lives he has discussed so far.

Hebrews 11:14–16

Abraham's family clearly did not want to return to their homeland. If they did, they could have gone back. Their faith showed they longed for a better place. They hoped in God, who rewarded their faith by preparing a heavenly city for them.

Hebrews 11:17–19

ready to offer his one and only son: See Genesis 22:1–18. God did not want Abraham to sacrifice his son. He was testing Abraham's faith, which Abraham showed through his obedience.

Hebrews 11:17–31

These strong examples of faith start with Abraham's family and end with Rahab. They show that faith is the only way to respond to God.

Hebrews 11:19

Abraham reasoned: He thought that bringing Isaac back to life was the only solution to his problem. In Genesis 22:5, Abraham showed faith that Isaac would come back with him.

Hebrews 11:20

Isaac blessed: See Genesis 27:27–40. The only part of the story that could be seen as a blessing for Esau is that he would eventually break free from serving his brother. Later, Esau received blessings through Jacob's wealth (Genesis 33:8–11).

Hebrews 11:21

- Jacob gave the ritual blessing to Joseph's sons, Ephraim and Manasseh (Genesis 48:8–22).
- worshiped as he leaned on the top of his staff: Genesis 47:31. The phrase as he leaned on his staff comes from the Greek translation of the Old Testament.

Hebrews 11:22

Joseph's prophecy and command (see Genesis 50:24–25) showed his faith that God would keep his promises.

Hebrews 11:23

- Moses' parents: See Exodus 2:1–2.
- beautiful: This word means something of high quality. They believed Moses was special, so they acted with faith in God.
- the king's edict: Exodus 1:22.

Hebrews 11:24–25

Moses, when he was grown: He took a public stand with the people of Israel instead of being known as the son of Pharaoh's daughter, who had adopted him (see Exodus 2:11–15 and Exodus 2:3–10). He chose to share in the suffering of God's people, just as the readers of this letter were encouraged to do (see Hebrews 10:32–34).

Hebrews 11:26

the treasures of Egypt: The New Kingdom of Egypt lasted from about 1550 to 1069 BC. It was a time of great wealth and political power. Moses looked beyond these riches because he expected a greater reward from God.

Hebrews 11:27

- Like his ancestor Abraham, Moses showed faith by leaving Egypt, the land he knew, and stepping into an unknown future (Exodus 2:15).
- not fearing the king's anger: Instead of fearing the king's anger, he focused on God, who is invisible.

Hebrews 11:28

- he kept the Passover: See Exodus 12:1–27. The first Passover (Exodus 12:28–30) started the Exodus (Exodus 12:31–42, 50–51) and began the yearly Passover celebration as a remembrance (Exodus 12:43–49; 13:1–16).
- the sprinkling of blood: Sprinkling the blood of sacrifices in the old covenant was similar to the sprinkling of Christ's blood (see Hebrews 9:12–14, 18–22).

Hebrews 11:29

The rescue through the Red Sea (see Exodus 13:17–14:21) is the greatest moment of deliverance in Israel's history. The people's fear and complaints at the time (Exodus 14:10–12) do not clearly show faith, but they moved forward when instructed, despite their fear. This event shows that obedience is key to faith.

Hebrews 11:30

The conquest of Jericho (Joshua 5:13–6:27) shows great faith. The people followed God's unusual instructions obediently.

Hebrews 11:31

Rahab, a prostitute (Joshua 2; 6:25), showed faith in the God of Israel by hiding the spies who visited her home (see James 2:25). Because of this, she and her family were spared and became part of the Israelite community. Rahab was even an ancestor of Jesus (Matthew 1:5).

Hebrews 11:32

- And what more shall I say? The author transitions to a concluding summary, starting with six faith heroes from the time of the judges and the united monarchy:
- Gideon defeated the Midianites using torches and jars (Judges 7:7–25).
- Barak defeated Sisera and the Canaanites (Judges 4:8–16).
- Samson, despite his moral weaknesses, was used by God to fight the Philistines for Israel (Judges 13–16).

- Jephthah achieved victory over the Amorites and Ammonites (Judges 10:6–12:7).
- David, the only king in the group, loved God and generally led a life of faith (1 Samuel 16—1 Kings 1).
- Samuel was a key leader between the time of the judges and Israel's first kings. He listened to God's voice and followed his will (1 Samuel 1–15).
- The phrase and the prophets includes Elijah, Elisha, and the prophets from Isaiah to Malachi. These prophets often showed great faith despite facing hostility.

Hebrews 11:32–40

The author quickly highlights other faithful people from the old covenant era. In Hebrews 11:32–35a, faith leads to rescue and triumph. In 11:35b–38, however, faith results in harsh persecution and even death for their beliefs. Despite these outcomes, God honored both groups with a good reputation because of their faith (11:39).

Hebrews 11:33

- conquered kingdoms: During the time of the judges and the time when David was king, Israel defeated many enemies. David, Solomon, and a few others ruled fairly (see 2 Samuel 8:15; 1 Kings 10:9).
- shut the mouths of lions: See Daniel 6:1–23.

Hebrews 11:34

- quenched the raging fire: See Daniel 3:16–30.
- escaped the edge of the sword: For example, Elijah and Jeremiah (see 1 Kings 19:2; 2 Kings 1:1–18; Jeremiah 26:10–16; 38:1–13).

Hebrews 11:35

- Elijah and Elisha both brought women's loved ones back from death (see 1 Kings 17:17–24; 2 Kings 4:17–37).
- Others were tortured: Faith does not always lead to a positive outcome in this life. The author might be referring to the 170s and 160s BC, when many Jews suffered and died rather than abandon their faith (see, for example, 1 Maccabees 1:20–64).

Hebrews 11:37

Tradition says that people killed the prophet Jeremiah by throwing stones at him, and they sawed the prophet Isaiah in half.

Hebrews 11:38

The world was not worthy of them: They placed their hope in God more than in the pleasures and comforts of life.

Hebrews 11:39–40

- The way to live as God's people under the new covenant is the same way people lived under the old covenant: by trusting God's promises and enduring difficulties in this world.
- commended for their faith: God recognized their faithfulness (see also Hebrews 11:2).
- yet they did not receive what was promised: They died before Christ's promised coming. The better promise began with Christ's sacrifice (8:3–10:18) and looks forward to the future completion of God's plan for his people.
- they would be made perfect: See study notes on 5:9; 7:11. Jesus has fulfilled God's goal of bringing his people into a relationship with him.

Hebrews 12:1

- a great cloud of witnesses: The many faithful followers of God (Hebrews 11) show that God rewards a life of faith.
- let us throw off every encumbrance: In Greco-Roman writings, a race symbolizes the need for endurance in life. Just as extra weight slows a runner, sin ... easily entagles us and keeps us from living by faith.

Hebrews 12:1–17

The author encourages listeners to keep following Jesus, who is the ultimate example of faithfulness. They should:

- imitate him in his suffering (Hebrews 12:1–4),
- endure God's discipline (12:5–13), and
- live peacefully with others (12:14–17).

Hebrews 12:2

- Jesus is the ultimate example of staying faithful (Hebrews 3:1). To endure in the Christian life, we must focus on Jesus and his work for us.
- Jesus, the author and perfecter of our faith: Jesus has done everything needed for faith to be real under the new covenant.
- scorning its shame: Crucifixion (dying on a cross) was the most shameful way to execute someone. It was used to humiliate and torture the person crucified. It was used only for slaves and criminals who were not Roman citizens. Christ ignored that shame.

- sat down at the right hand of the throne of God: The author refers again to Psalm 110:1 (see also Hebrews 1:3, 13; 8:1; 10:12).

Hebrews 12:3

Think of all the hostility he endured from sinful people. The recipients of Hebrews were tired and ready to give up. They were emotionally worn out due to the persecution they faced. To endure, they needed to focus on Jesus, who had faced even greater hostility.

Hebrews 12:4

not yet resisted to the point of shedding your blood: This community had not yet faced dying for their faith. (This is one reason to date Hebrews before Nero's persecution in the mid-60s AD.) If Jesus could endure a shameful death, the listeners should handle less severe persecution.

Hebrews 12:5–6

These verses quote Proverbs 3:11–12, which sees hardship as God's loving discipline for his children. God can use many trials and challenges for our benefit, teaching us righteousness and good character.

Hebrews 12:7–8

discipline ... God is treating you as sons: Fathers in Greco-Roman and Jewish families played a key role in raising their children. They believed discipline was essential for preparing children for adulthood. Fatherly discipline, in this case facing hardships in life, is a sign of legitimate relationship. Not having to face hardships may on the surface seem like a blessing, but might instead reflect a lack of genuine relationship.

Hebrews 12:9

The author uses a comparison from lesser to greater (see study note on Hebrews 9:14). The lesser situation is the respect given to an earthly father during discipline. We should submit even more to the discipline of the Father of our spirits in our relationship with God. We should be open to God like a good Father, trusting that he helps us grow, even through tough times.

Hebrews 12:10–11

There are at least two limits to a father's discipline:

1. His discipline or education lasts only a few years—children eventually leave home.
2. Fathers do their best with limited understanding.

In contrast, God's discipline lasts a lifetime and is always beneficial, based on his infinite knowledge and love. His goal is for us to share in his holiness. Although discipline is painful, it leads to a peaceful life of doing right. It helps God's children build harmonious relationships and make good choices (see also Romans 5:3–4; 8:17, 28; 2 Corinthians 4:17; Philippians 1:12–14; James 1:2–4; 1 Peter 1:7; 4:14).

Hebrews 12:12–13

The author, referring to Isaiah 35:3–8 and Proverbs 4:26, offers support to those who feel emotionally and spiritually drained. Isaiah 35 says God is always working to defeat his enemies and create a clear path for righteous people, so they will not stumble.

Hebrews 12:14

People living a holy life have confident hope of seeing the Lord (see 1 John 2:28; 3:21; 4:17).

Hebrews 12:15

root of bitterness: This refers to those people who abandon God's agreement to worship other gods (Deuteronomy 29:18). Bitterness can harm the church.

Hebrews 12:16

- Ancient Jewish writings describe Esau as sexually immoral because he married Hittite women, Judith and Basemath (Genesis 26:34; see Jubilees 25:1; Philo, On the Virtues 208).
- Esau showed disrespect for his birthright (Genesis 25:29–34), which is why he was considered godless. His choice to trade God's blessings for immediate fulfillment shows a lack of faith.

Hebrews 12:17

The author of Hebrews views Esau's lack of respect for his inheritance (Hebrews 12:16) and his loss of the blessing (Genesis 27:30–40) as closely connected. This led to his bitter tears. By extension, those who reject an inheritance through Christ's new covenant will face a future filled with bitterness.

Hebrews 12:18

The descriptions of Mount Sinai are based on God's meeting with Israel there (see Exodus 19:16–22; 20:18–21; Deuteronomy 4:11–12; 5:23–27). These images show separation from a holy God.

Hebrews 12:18–24

This passage compares the old covenant with the new one. The old covenant is represented by Mount Sinai (12:18–21). It was impersonal, frightening, and unapproachable. The mountain shook with loud sounds,

flashes of light, and fearful power. The new covenant is represented by Mount Zion (12:22–24). It is personal, welcoming, and joyful.

Hebrews 12:19

The loud trumpet sound and a voice scared the people (see Exodus 19:16, 19; 20:18; Deuteronomy 4:12) so much that they asked God to stop speaking (Exodus 20:19).

Hebrews 12:22

- Instead: There is a clear difference between the old and new covenant. Believers now come to the amazing Mount Zion, closely linked with Jerusalem, representing God's home.
- heavenly Jerusalem: See study note on Hebrews 8:5.
- The new covenant creates a relationship with God, allowing us to experience his presence with joy, peace, and fellowship.

Hebrews 12:23

- The word translated as assembly is usually translated "church." It refers to God's gathered people.
- God's firstborn children are those who are part of the new covenant (see Hebrews 1:6; 2:10–13).
- The idea that God's people have their names written in heaven shows God's special care for them (see also Exodus 32:32; Psalm 69:28; Isaiah 4:3; Daniel 12:1; Luke 10:20; Philippians 4:3; Revelation 3:5).
- For God's children, God as judge is the one who defends them (see Psalms 9:8; 58:11; 94:2; Isaiah 11:4; Jeremiah 22:16).
- Those who have died are now made perfect through Christ's sacrifice (Hebrews 10:14).

Hebrews 12:24

- Jesus is the mediator of the new covenant (Hebrews 8:7–13; 9:11–14; 10:15–18). His sprinkled blood, used as the sacrifice for sins, represents forgiveness.
- Abel's blood cried out to God from the ground, seeking justice for his murder by Cain (Genesis 4:10). In contrast, the blood of Jesus declares that the price for sins is paid for those in the new covenant (Hebrews 10:16–18).

Hebrews 12:25

God speaks through his Son, Jesus (Hebrews 1:1–3). The author compares two situations:

1. Moses warning people under the old covenant is less serious.
2. God's warning from heaven is more serious.

If people did not avoid judgment when warned by Moses, those who reject the message of God's Son will definitely not avoid punishment.

Hebrews 12:25–29

This passage serves as the book's final warning, referencing God speaking in Hebrews 2:1–4, 4:12–13, 6:4–8, 10:26–31, and 12:18–24.

Hebrews 12:26–27

- shook the earth: Exodus 19:18; Judges 5:5; Psalms 68:8; 77:18.
- "Once more I will shake not only the earth, but heaven as well": This quote from Haggai 2:6 highlights that all of creation will be shaken and removed during the final judgment at the end of time (1 Corinthians 7:31; 2 Peter 3:10, 12; Revelation 21:1).

Hebrews 12:28–29

- God deserves holy fear and awe.
- our God is a consuming fire: This quote from Deuteronomy 4:24 highlights God's incredible power and his authority to judge.

Hebrews 13:1

Continue in brotherly love: This advice to keep on loving each other like family is for everyone in the Christian community (see study notes on Hebrews 2:11; 3:1).

Hebrews 13:1–6

This set of practical guidelines is like other ethical lists in the New Testament. It explains how to love others in the faith community, providing a strong ethical foundation for life.

Hebrews 13:2

- Hospitality is an important principle in Jewish and Christian ethics (1 Peter 4:9; see also Matthew 10:11; Acts 16:15; Titus 3:13; Philemon 1:22; 3 John 1:5–8). In the first century, travelers usually did not stay at inns.
- some people have entertained angels without knowing it: See Genesis 18:2–15; Judges 13:2–23.

Hebrews 13:3

Remember those in prison: Prisoners often relied on family and friends for basic needs. Christians were encouraged to offer comfort, food, prayer, and other essentials to those jailed for their faith (Hebrews

13:18–19; Matthew 25:36; Colossians 4:18; 2 Timothy 1:16).

Hebrews 13:4

- To honor marriage means to protect it and see it as very important.
- Sexually immoral refers to any inappropriate sexual behavior.
- Adultery breaks the marriage promise by having sexual relations outside the marriage.

Hebrews 13:5

Keep your lives free from the love of money: See 1 Timothy 6:6–10. Instead, believers should be content with what God has given them. Some in the community might have faced financial difficulties (see Hebrews 10:32–34). God's promises remain true: "Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you" (see Deuteronomy 31:6, 8).

Hebrews 13:6

This quote from Psalm 118:6 shows a response of faith: The Lord is my helper, so we do not need to fear what others might do.

Hebrews 13:7

Remember your leaders: The word leaders referred to military, political, and religious figures. These leaders, likely founders of this community, taught the word of God to them, which is a basic duty of those who lead (see 1 Timothy 3:2; 2 Timothy 2:15; Titus 1:9). Their lives and faith were examples to follow.

Hebrews 13:7–19

This middle part of chapter 13 is framed by mentions of the community's leaders (13:7, 17–19). Rabbis often used a technique called inclusio, where similar words or phrases mark the start and end of a section, like a subheading in a modern book. This part suggests there were several challenges in the church that the book of Hebrews originally addressed.

Hebrews 13:8

- Even though the community faced new challenges, Jesus Christ remains the same, and his good news does not change.
- yesterday: Jesus was the Father's agent in creation (Hebrews 1:2, 10).
- today: Jesus sits at the Father's right hand (1:13; 7:26–28; 10:12). He will rule the universe forever (1:8, 10–12).

Hebrews 13:9–10

Since Jesus does not change (Hebrews 13:8), believers should avoid being drawn to strange, new ideas. The false teachings mentioned involved rules about food. In some parts of Judaism, certain ritual meals were thought to provide God's grace to participants. Some in the community might have been tempted to leave the Christian community to join Jewish fellowship meals. These Jewish meals sometimes encouraged participants to focus on the Jerusalem altar. The author reminds listeners that we have an altar that those under the old covenant cannot access—Christ's sacrifice (7:27–28; 8:13; 9:11–14; 10:11–14).

Hebrews 13:11–12

The author explains the sacrifice on the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 16:1–28), where animals were burned outside the camp (Leviticus 16:27). Similarly, Jesus suffered and died outside Jerusalem's city gates. He was the ultimate Day of Atonement sacrifice (Hebrews 9:11–14, 24–28; 10:1–4).

Hebrews 13:13

let us go to Him outside the camp: We should stand with Jesus, identify with him, and reject the false safety and comfort of siding with the world against him. By standing with Christ, we share in the disgrace he experienced (Hebrews 6:5–6; 12:1–3).

Hebrews 13:14

Like Abraham's family (Hebrews 11:9–16), we do not see this world as our permanent home. We are waiting for our future home, the heavenly city of Jerusalem (12:22).

Hebrews 13:15

sacrifice of praise: This likely refers to a peace offering (Leviticus 7:11–14). The person bringing the offering needed to be ritually clean first. We can continually offer thanks to God because Jesus has made us clean forever. By giving thanks to Jesus all the time, we show our loyalty to his name.

Hebrews 13:15–16

Because of Jesus and his decisive and sacrificial work for us, Christians still have sacrifices to offer to God. These sacrifices are praise and obedience. Christ ended the old covenant sacrifices when he gave himself as the final sacrifice (Hebrews 7:27–28; 8:13; 9:11–14; 10:11–14). Now these spiritual sacrifices are the ones that please God.

Hebrews 13:16

Doing good and helping those in need are basic Christian sacrifices (Hebrews 6:10; 10:24, 34; 13:1–3). These actions define life in the Christian community.

Hebrews 13:17

- The relationship between the church's spiritual leaders and its members might have been tense. The author encourages members to listen to and trust their leaders.
- The Greek word for obey can also mean follow, place confidence in, or be persuaded by.
- Christian leaders care for people's souls (Acts 20:28–31; 1 Peter 5:1–4), which is a serious responsibility. It makes them accountable to God (James 3:1).
- The word grief could also mean groaning. It refers to emotional burden and stress. Leaders who are stressed and burdened by a difficult church are less able to help and lead the church effectively.

Hebrews 13:18–19

- Pray for us: The author requests prayers for himself using the "authorial plural" (a literary device where the author uses "we" instead of "I") (see also 5:11; 6:9).
- we have a clear conscience: Compare with 2 Corinthians 1:11–12; 4:2.

Hebrews 13:20–21

- Benedictions, or closing blessings, were an important part of letters, speeches, and sermons. The author of Hebrews includes many of the book's main themes in his benediction.
- The image of our Lord Jesus as the great Shepherd of the sheep (see Psalm 23) shows God's care and protection for his people (see also John 10:11–18; 1 Peter 2:25) and connects it to an eternal covenant.

Hebrews 13:22

This short encouragement likely shows that Hebrews was a sermon (compare with the same term in Acts 13:14–15, translated as "encouragement").

Hebrews 13:23

This Timothy might have traveled with Paul (see "Timothy" Profile). If that's the case, the New Testament does not mention his imprisonment. He clearly knows both the author and the recipients of this letter.

Hebrews 13:24–25

- The book ends with a formal greeting and a blessing.
- Those from Italy: The author is likely writing back to Rome from another place in the Mediterranean world. Some scholars, however, think the author may have been writing from Rome itself.